

Recognizing and Responding to Heart Attack and Stroke Warning Signs

FRONT MATTER

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When in doubt, call 911.

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QRU Lesson Footer

QRU Interactive Lesson

CHAPTER 1

Recognizing and Responding to Heart Attack and Stroke Warning Signs

Emergency readiness skill: Identify warning signs, call for help quickly, and support the person safely while waiting for emergency responders.

Educational Disclaimer

This lesson is for education only. It does not replace emergency medical care, professional first-aid/CPR training, or instructions from emergency services.

If you think someone may be having a heart attack or stroke, call 911 or your local emergency number immediately.

CHAPTER 2

Learning Goals

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

- Recognize common warning signs of a heart attack
- Recognize common warning signs of a stroke
- Use FAST and BE-FAST to remember stroke warning signs
- Take safe first steps while waiting for emergency help

Practice what to say when calling 911

Decide when to act instead of waiting

CHAPTER 3

Key Plain-Language Definitions

Heart attack: A medical emergency that happens when blood flow to part of the heart is blocked.

Stroke: A medical emergency that happens when blood flow to part of the brain is blocked or when bleeding occurs in the brain.

Last known well: The last time the person was known to be normal, without stroke symptoms.

Dispatcher: The emergency call-taker who answers 911 and gives instructions until help arrives.

The Most Important Rule

CHAPTER 4

When in doubt, call 911.

If you suspect a heart attack or stroke:

Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately

Do not wait to see if symptoms go away

Do not drive the person to the hospital yourself unless emergency services tells you to

Follow dispatcher instructions

Fast action can save a life and reduce long-term damage.

Part 1: Heart Attack Warning Signs

A heart attack can be sudden and intense, but it can also start slowly with mild discomfort.

Symptoms may come and go. They may feel like pressure, pain, heaviness, burning, or tightness.

CHAPTER 5

Common Heart Attack Warning Signs

Call 911 if someone has any of the following, especially if symptoms are new, severe, unusual, or do not quickly improve:

- Chest pain, pressure, squeezing, fullness, or discomfort

- Pain or discomfort spreading to the:

 - Arm

 - Shoulder

 - Back

 - Neck

 - Jaw

 - Stomach

 - Shortness of breath

 - Cold sweat

 - Nausea or vomiting

 - Lightheadedness, dizziness, or fainting

 - Unusual tiredness or weakness, especially if sudden or unexplained

A sense that “something is very wrong”

CHAPTER 6

Important Note: Symptoms Can Look Different

Heart attack symptoms may not look the same for everyone.

Women, older adults, and people with diabetes may have less obvious symptoms, such as:

Shortness of breath

Nausea

Unusual fatigue

Back, neck, jaw, or stomach discomfort

Lightheadedness

Weakness without severe chest pain

Do not ignore mild or unusual symptoms if they could be heart-related.

CHAPTER 7

Heart Attack Response Steps

If you think someone may be having a heart attack:

1. Call 911 immediately.
2. Have the person sit or rest in a comfortable position.
3. Keep the person calm and still.
4. Loosen tight clothing, such as a tight collar, tie, belt, or

waistband.

5. Do not give food or drink.
6. Do not give aspirin unless emergency dispatch or a medical professional recommends it, and only if the person is not allergic and has no known reason they should avoid it.
7. Monitor breathing and responsiveness.
8. Be ready to start CPR or use an AED if the person becomes unresponsive and you are trained or instructed by the dispatcher.
9. Stay with the person until help arrives.
10. Follow dispatcher instructions.

CHAPTER 8

Quick Check 1: Could This Be a Heart Attack?

8.1 Scenario

Your uncle says he has heavy pressure in his chest. He is sweating, feels nauseated, and says the discomfort is spreading to his jaw.

What should you do first?

- A. Offer him food and water
- B. Wait 30 minutes to see if it improves
- C. Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately
- D. Drive him yourself without calling

8.2 Correct Answer

- C. Call 911 or your local emergency number immediately.

Chest pressure, sweating, nausea, and pain spreading to the jaw are possible heart attack signs. Fast emergency care matters.

CHAPTER 9

Decision Prompt: Wait or Call?

For each situation, decide: Call 911 now or Wait and watch.

Situation Best Response

A person has chest pressure and shortness of breath. Call 911 now

A person has sudden jaw discomfort, nausea, and cold sweating. Call 911 now

A person says, “It’s probably nothing,” but they look pale, weak, and dizzy. Call 911 now

A person has mild chest discomfort after exercise that feels unusual and does not quickly improve. Call 911 now

9.1 QRU Safety Reminder

If symptoms could be a heart attack, do not wait for certainty. Emergency responders would rather be called early than too late.

CHAPTER 10

Practice Script: Calling 911 for a Possible Heart Attack

Use a calm, clear voice.

- > “I need an ambulance. I think someone may be having a heart attack.
- > We are at [give exact address/location].
- > The person has [describe symptoms: chest pressure, sweating, nausea, shortness of breath].
- > Symptoms started about [time].
- > The person is [awake/not awake, breathing/not breathing].
- > I will stay on the line and follow your instructions.”

Part 2: Stroke Warning Signs

A stroke happens when blood flow to part of the brain is blocked or when bleeding occurs in the brain.

Stroke symptoms often appear suddenly.

A stroke is always an emergency. Quick treatment may reduce brain damage and disability.

CHAPTER 11

Use FAST First

FAST is a simple way to remember major stroke warning signs.

Letter	Meaning	What to Check
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F	Face drooping	Ask the person to smile. Is one side of the face drooping or numb?
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A	Arm weakness	Ask the person to raise both arms. Does one arm drift down? Is one arm weak or numb?
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S	Speech difficulty	Ask the person to repeat a simple sentence.
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Is speech slurred, strange, confused, or hard to understand?

T Time to call 911 If you see any of these signs, call 911 immediately.

CHAPTER 12

BE-FAST: More Stroke Warning Signs

BE-FAST adds two more warning signs that may also happen suddenly.

Letter	Meaning	Warning Sign
--------	---------	--------------

B	Balance	Sudden trouble walking, dizziness, or loss of balance/coordination
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E	Eyes	Sudden trouble seeing in one or both eyes
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F	Face	Face drooping or numbness
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A	Arms	Arm weakness or numbness
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S	Speech	Trouble speaking, understanding, or slurred speech
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T	Time	Time to call 911 immediately
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CHAPTER 13

Other Stroke Warning Signs

Call 911 immediately if someone suddenly has:

Numbness or weakness, especially on one side of the body

Confusion

Trouble speaking

Trouble understanding speech

Trouble seeing in one or both eyes
Trouble walking
Dizziness
Loss of balance or coordination
Sudden severe headache with no known cause
Face drooping
Arm weakness
Speech difficulty

Even if symptoms go away, the person still needs urgent medical care.

Stroke Response Steps

If you think someone may be having a stroke:

1. Call 911 immediately.
2. Note the time symptoms started.
3. If you do not know when symptoms started, note the time the person was last known well.
4. Do not give food, drink, or medication unless emergency dispatch or a medical professional tells you to.
5. Keep the person safe and resting.
6. Do not let the person drive.
7. Monitor breathing and responsiveness.
8. Be ready to start CPR or use an AED if the person becomes unresponsive and you are trained or instructed by the dispatcher.
9. Stay with the person until help arrives.
10. Follow dispatcher instructions.

CHAPTER 14

Why Time Matters During Stroke

Some stroke treatments depend on when symptoms started.

That is why it is important to tell emergency responders:

The exact time symptoms started, if known

The time the person was last known well, if the start time is unknown

What symptoms you noticed first

Whether symptoms changed or improved

CHAPTER 15

Quick Check 2: Use FAST

15.1 Scenario

Your coworker suddenly starts speaking in a confused way. When you ask her to smile, one side of her face droops. She says her arm feels weak.

What should you do?

- A. Give her water and help her lie down for a nap
- B. Call 911 immediately and note the time symptoms started
- C. Drive her home and ask a family member to watch her
- D. Wait to see if she feels better in an hour

15.2 Correct Answer

B. Call 911 immediately and note the time symptoms started.

Face drooping, arm weakness, and speech difficulty are classic stroke warning signs.

CHAPTER 16

Quick Check 3: BE-FAST

16.1 Scenario

A family member suddenly becomes dizzy, cannot walk straight, and says their vision is blurry in one eye.

Which BE-FAST signs are present?

- A. Balance and Eyes
- B. Face and Arms only
- C. Time only
- D. None, because there is no chest pain

16.2 Correct Answer

- A. Balance and Eyes

Sudden dizziness, trouble walking, loss of balance, or vision changes can be stroke warning signs. Call 911 immediately.

CHAPTER 17

Decision Prompt: Stroke or Not?

Read each situation. If it could be a stroke, choose Call 911 now.

Situation Best Response

Sudden face drooping and slurred speech Call 911 now

Sudden weakness on one side of the body Call 911 now

Sudden severe headache with no known cause Call 911 now

Sudden trouble seeing in one eye Call 911 now

Symptoms improve after 10 minutes Call 911 now

17.1 QRU Safety Reminder

Stroke symptoms that disappear can still be serious. Call 911 even if the person seems to recover.

CHAPTER 18

Practice Script: Calling 911 for a Possible Stroke

- > “I need an ambulance. I think someone may be having a stroke.
- > We are at [give exact address/location].
- > The person has [describe symptoms: face drooping, arm weakness, speech trouble, vision trouble, dizziness, severe headache].
- > Symptoms started at [time], or they were last known well at [time].
- > The person is [awake/not awake, breathing/not breathing].
- > I will stay on the line and follow your instructions.”

Part 3: Heart Attack vs. Stroke

Summary Table

Emergency First Action	What Is Happening?	Common Warning Signs
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Heart Attack	Blood flow to part of the heart is blocked	Chest pressure/pain, shortness of breath, sweating, nausea, pain spreading to arm/back/neck/jaw/stomach, dizziness, unusual fatigue
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Call 911 immediately

Stroke	Blood flow to part of the brain is blocked or bleeding occurs in the brain	Face drooping, arm weakness, speech difficulty, sudden numbness/weakness, confusion, vision trouble, dizziness, trouble walking, loss of balance, sudden severe headache
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Call 911 immediately

Part 4: Safe Waiting Steps

While waiting for emergency responders:

CHAPTER 19

For a Possible Heart Attack

Keep the person seated or resting

Keep them calm and still

Loosen tight clothing

Do not give food or drink

Do not give aspirin unless recommended by dispatch or a medical professional

Monitor breathing and responsiveness

Be ready to start CPR/AED if trained or instructed

CHAPTER 20

For a Possible Stroke

Keep the person safe and resting

Note symptom start time or last known well time

Do not give food, drink, or medication unless directed

Do not let the person drive

Monitor breathing and responsiveness

Be ready to start CPR/AED if trained or instructed

QRU Review: Remember the Life-Saving Pattern

CHAPTER 21

Recognize. Call. Stay. Follow.

1. Recognize warning signs.
2. Call 911 immediately.
3. Stay with the person.
4. Follow dispatcher instructions.

CHAPTER 22

Memory Reinforcement

22.1 Heart Attack Clues

Think: Chest + Breathing + Sweating + Nausea + Spreading Pain

Heart attack discomfort may spread to the:

Arm

Shoulder

Back

Neck

Jaw

Stomach

22.2 Stroke Clues

Think: BE-FAST

B — Balance

E — Eyes

F — Face

A — Arms

S — Speech

T — Time to call 911

Final Knowledge Check

Choose the best answer.

CHAPTER 23

Question 1

A person has chest pressure, shortness of breath, and cold sweating. What should you do first?

- A. Wait to see if it goes away
- B. Call 911 immediately
- C. Give a large meal
- D. Tell them to drive to the hospital

23.1 Answer

- B. Call 911 immediately

CHAPTER 24

Question 2

Which stroke memory tool reminds you to check face, arms, speech, and time?

- A. CPR
- B. FAST
- C. RICE
- D. ABC

24.1 Answer

- B. FAST

CHAPTER 25

Question 3

A person suddenly has trouble speaking and one arm is weak.
What should you do?

- A. Call 911 immediately
- B. Give them water
- C. Wait one hour
- D. Ask them to sleep it off

25.1 Answer

- A. Call 911 immediately

CHAPTER 26

Question 4

For a possible stroke, why should you note the time symptoms started or when the person was last known well?

- A. It helps emergency responders and may affect treatment options
- B. It helps decide whether the person should eat
- C. It is only needed for paperwork
- D. It is not important

26.1 Answer

- A. It helps emergency responders and may affect treatment options

CHAPTER 27

Question 5

Which action is safest while waiting for help during a possible heart attack?

- A. Encourage the person to walk around
- B. Give aspirin to everyone
- C. Keep the person seated or resting and follow dispatcher instructions
- D. Give food and drink

27.1 Answer

C. Keep the person seated or resting and follow dispatcher instructions

CHAPTER 28

Question 6

A person's stroke-like symptoms disappear after 10 minutes. What should you do?

- A. Ignore it because they recovered
- B. Call 911 because it may still be serious
- C. Give medication without medical direction
- D. Let them drive themselves to urgent care

28.1 Answer

B. Call 911 because it may still be serious

CHAPTER 29

Question 7

Which symptoms may be warning signs of stroke?

- A. Sudden vision trouble
- B. Sudden dizziness or loss of balance
- C. Sudden severe headache with no known cause
- D. All of the above

29.1 Answer

D. All of the above

Final Takeaway

CHAPTER 30

When in doubt, call 911.

Heart attacks and strokes are medical emergencies. You do not need to be certain before calling for help.

Your safest actions are:

- Recognize warning signs
- Call 911 immediately
- Follow dispatcher instructions
- Keep the person safe while waiting
- Be ready to begin CPR/AED if trained or instructed

CHAPTER 31

QRU Lesson Footer

QRU Emergency Readiness Principle:

Fast recognition plus fast action can save lives. When symptoms suggest a heart attack or stroke, call 911 immediately — do not wait.

Continue your understanding at QRU:

